



KYOTO JAPAN

Fine Dining in Kyoto

The imperial capital for half a millennium until 1869, Kyoto is the cradle of Japanese culture and its historical and spiritual heart. Geishas wander its cherry-tree-lined streets and lanterns are lit at night, when the appetizing smell of cooking fills the air. The pinnacle of Kyoto's culinary heritage – the highly refined, multi-course *kaiseki* – lives on in the city's historic *ryotei* restaurants.



Kyoto is such a perfect distillation of Japanese culture that at times it can feel like a theme park.

Spared the destructive might of Allied bombing at the end of World War II, large parts of the city remain well preserved, affording evocative glimpses of life in feudal-era Japan. This is where you will find Japan's most seductive Zen gardens, its most impressive temples, and, of course, the fabled geishas, women who are formally trained to entertain men with music, dance, and conversation; they are easily distinguished by their formal white makeup, wigs, and elaborate kimonos. Costume geishas roam the main tourist district, Gion, for the benefit of the cameras, but you can sometimes spot the real thing on Pontocho, the restaurant and nightlife street.

Kyoto's famous tea ceremony represents the pinnacle of the city's ritual aesthetic, with its impressively controlled and precise choreography. Food-lovers owe it a debt of gratitude, as it led to the creation of a gastronomic treat. Needing some food to counteract all the bitter green tea, the imperial court came up with the similarly ritualized and prolonged multi-course *kaiseki*, Japan's answer to *haute cuisine*.

Perfection, subtlety, and above all seasonality are the watchwords of the *kaiseki* chef. *Kaiseki* meals are traditionally served to diners seated on *tatami* (rice-straw mats) in the minimally furnished private rooms of *ryotei* – traditional restaurants housed in old wooden buildings, usually overlooking immaculate gardens. The menu is fixed and can run to over 20 courses, each with a specific name; the finest *kaiseki* meals cost at least 50,000 yen (\$600) – often much more. The *sakizuke* is the first dish, the all-important overture; ensuing courses draw attention to an aspect of Japan's seasonal bounty, such as spring mountain ferns in May or the fiercely expensive *matsutake* mushroom in fall. Even the tableware plays a role in reflecting the seasonal narrative of the meal.

For the *kaiseki* novice, there will almost certainly be alien and quite possibly alarming ingredients – sea cucumber roe, salted fish entrails, or snapping turtle, for instance – as well as unfamiliar mealy, soft, and crunchy textures. There will be little or no meat and some dishes might not even taste like very much, but everything will look exquisite. *Dashi*, a stock made from seaweed and *katsubushi* (dried bonito flakes), forms the core of any *kaiseki*, but it will invariably end with rice, the foodstuff the Japanese hold most dear.



Above *Kaiseki* is a succession of courses that aim to balance texture, temperature, and flavor, while emphasizing the essential character of the season

Right The Golden Pavilion in the Rukon-ji complex is one of many beautiful temple buildings in Kyoto

Below In Kyoto, geishas and *maiko* (apprentice geishas) dress their hair and bodies in 18th-century style



A Day in Kyoto

Kyoto has more than 2,000 temples, shrines, and gardens, many of them UNESCO World Heritage sites, so selectivity is the key for sightseeing Kyoto in one day.

MORNING Start at **Nanzen-ji**, which is a good example of the type of temple most common to Kyoto; it is also situated close to many other temples in **Higashiyama**, a wonderful area to wander. For lunch, make for the legendary **Nishiki Market**, a covered corridor filled with dried-fish vendors, grocers selling bewildering indigenous Kyoto vegetables, Japanese sweet shops, and ancient knifemakers who once fashioned samurai swords and still service the imperial kitchen equipment.

AFTERNOON Visit the **Kyoto International Manga Museum** for a modern take on Japan, or explore the **Imperial Palace** for a more historical one. Then stroll around the atmospheric residential area of **Kamigyo ku**; there is a surprise on every street.

EVENING End the day on the outdoor restaurant terraces of **Pontocho**, watching the bats swoop over the Kamo River.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

The “bullet train” from Tokyo takes around 2½ hours. The nearest **airport** is Kansai International, 75 minutes away by **train**.

WHERE TO STAY

Ryokan Ishihara (inexpensive) is a traditional Japanese inn that warmly welcomes foreigners. www.yado-web.com

APA Hotel (moderate) is a modern hotel close to the main station. www.apahotel.com

Tawaraya (expensive) is a superb, 300-year-old traditional Japanese *ryokan*. +81 75 211 5566

TOURIST INFORMATION

www.seejapan.co.uk

What Else to Eat

Kyoto is cradled on three sides by mountains that provide the clear, clean water so essential for its *sake* and tea. The soft, pure water is also important in the manufacture of Kyoto's renowned **tofu**, a key element of the city's cuisine. It used to be delivered fresh to homes every morning, like milk. Kyotoites enjoy tofu simmered in a hot pot, deep-fried (**agedashi tofu**), freeze-dried, or spread with miso and grilled as **dengaku**, among many preparations. They especially value dried tofu skin, or **yuba**. There are several excellent tofu restaurants in Kyoto, many of them located close to the main temples. One of the most famous is **Okutan**, close to the Nanzen-ji temple (+81 75 771 8709).